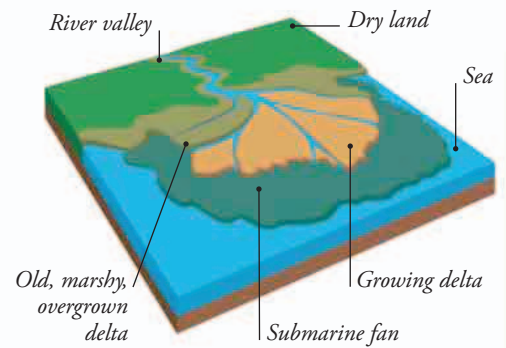




DEEP LAYERS

Deltas grow upward and outward as the river builds up layer after layer of mud, silt, and sand. These may extend far across the seafloor as a submarine fan. Eventually, the immense weight of the sediment warps the Earth's crust downward, and it continues to build up in very deep layers. The Bengal Fan that extends beyond the Ganges Delta is about 10 miles (16 km) thick.



WOW!

The Ganges Delta is the biggest in the world, covering 41,000 sq miles (105,000 sq km)—more than the total area of Tasmania.



▲ BANKS OF THE NILE

The lush farmland of the Nile Delta in Egypt fed the ancient Egyptians, who built the pyramids and the tombs of kings such as Tutankhamun.

FERTILE LAND

The inland parts of the delta become overgrown with freshwater marsh plants. Over centuries, the cycle of plant growth and decay creates very fertile soil that makes rich farmland. Many ancient civilizations depended on the wealth created by farming these delta soils. Today, ancient delta sediments are also some of the best sources of coal, oil, and natural gas.

WILDLIFE REFUGES

The inland swamps, creeks, and pools of a river delta often support a rich variety of wetland wildlife.

This includes fish, turtles, and alligators, as well as birds such as herons and fish eagles. The Danube

Delta in eastern Europe, for example, teems with freshwater fish.

These feed vast flocks of eastern white pelicans, and so the delta is now home to 70 percent of the world's white pelican population.

